money on transport. Mrs Peshawaria would be up at four in the morning to attend to the first chore of the day, which was to ensure that the milkman milked the cow in her presence to avoid any adulteration. After an early breakfast the sisters would jog or walk around 5 kilometres to reach the bus stand. At that time, the fare, at concessional rates for children under fourteen, was seven paise per child each way. To save this amount they would sometimes seek a lift from their more affluent friends who were driven to school in tongas. Saving this money meant earning money for their parents. Whatever was saved was always handed over to their mother. Sometimes there were some awkward moments when explanations had to be given for the delay in payment of fees. 'Shashi would do the explaining, as she was the eldest and in the seventh class. I must have been the first or the second and therefore was adequately covered by her explanation. But even today I can recollect the storm it would create in me whenever such moments occurred,' Kiran recalls. After all, it was not as if they were poor; it was only that the family's finances were controlled by a close-fisted, autocratic and insensitive grandfather. It was thus very early in life that Kiran developed this streak of determination when she promised herself that she would make sure that every paisa invested on her by her parents would be optimally utilized and accounted for. It was almost with a vengeance that she flung herself into whatever activity the school provided. She was into tennis, NCC (National Cadet Corps), use of the library, debates, declamations, dramas, athletics and more. She was determined that not a single moment that had been bought by her parents' money would go unrewarded.

When Kiran reached Class IX she took her first major decision in life, on her own. She had completed Class VIII and was having problems with getting the right combination of subjects for the ninth class. She was not overly partial to mathematics but wanted to take up science. That, however, was not possible at the Sacred Heart Convent. She was instead offered a subject course called 'household', where she would be taught how to budget home expenses, how to maintain and run a house and other skills that would help her in becoming a good and efficient housewife. That was enough to scare the living daylights out of the tomboyish Kiran and to set her free to abandon the school she so clearly loved in order to move over to any other institution that would keep her away from 'household' and mother-in-law concepts. She explored possibilities outside her school and came to know that a private institution called Cambridge College would offer her science with Hindi and would prepare her for the Class X board examinations. She was excited about the prospect of this 'double promotion' that was being offered to her and decided she would go for it. Her father was not in town to advise her and her mother readily agreed, saying that if she thought that was good for her then that is what she should do. So, while her peers in school cleared their ninth class, Kiran cleared her matriculation. She worked for and got her 'double promotion' to the envy of all her friends. It is a different matter that if she had managed to get only one mark less in Hindi she would have been back with them! Nevertheless, she had taken the first major decision of her life and it had come out right.